

Government has been overthrown. Long live the workers, soldiers, and peasant revolution!" After this initial triumph, Lenin was compelled to hold democratic elections, but the Bolsheviks received only a quarter of the vote. Lenin dissolved the elected government and sent armed guards to prevent it meeting again. In February 1918, he signed a peace treaty with Germany, but the terms were extremely harsh. Russia ceded the Baltic States to Germany, while Ukraine, Finland, and Estonia were transformed into independent states. Russia was also forced to pay six billion German marks in reparations. This move freed the Bolsheviks from the German threat, but the terms of the treaty were deeply unpopular. Many regarded it as a betrayal of their country.

Civil war

The Bolsheviks had gained power, but now they had to keep it. Lenin established a highly centralized government system, banned all opposition, and started the Red Terror, a campaign of intimidation, executions, and arrests against anybody perceived to be a threat to the Bolsheviks.

The Bolsheviks were a minority in Russia, and their opponents marshalled their forces against them, primarily the Whites, made up of former czarists, army officers, and democrats. The Bolsheviks were known as the Reds.

As various factions fought over the future of the country, a civil war characterized by extreme violence erupted in Russia and ran from 1918 to 1921. The Whites received help from Russia's former allies—Britain, France, the US, and Japan—which feared the spread of communism. At first, they made significant gains. However, they were badly coordinated, and Trotsky proved to be a brilliant military tactician.

In 1920, Lenin ordered a war against Poland to liberate the workers of eastern and central Europe, but at the Battle of Warsaw, after a magnificent counterattack, the Red Army was driven back.

A country in ruins

By 1921, the Whites had been defeated, and Lenin could finally turn his attention to rebuilding the Russian economy.

“The execution of the Czar and his family was needed not only to ... instill a sense of hopelessness in the enemy, but also to show that ahead lay total victory or total doom.

Leon Trotsky ”

He faced a country on the verge of collapse. In the countryside, around 6 million peasants had died of starvation, and there was rioting in the cities. The Kronstadt naval rebellion in March 1921 further undermined the regime. Kronstadt was a naval town on an island off the coast of Petrograd. In 1921, 16,000 soldiers and workers signed a petition calling for “Soviets without Bolsheviks”: freely elected Soviets and freedoms of speech and press. The Reds reacted ruthlessly, executing several hundred ringleaders and expelling over 15,000 sailors from the fleet.

In May 1922, Lenin suffered a stroke. In December, the Soviet government declared the establishment of the Union of Soviet Socialist Republics (USSR), a federal union consisting of Soviet Russia and neighboring areas that were ruled by branches of the communist movement. From its inception, the USSR was based on a premise of one-party rule, prohibiting all other political organizations.

Lenin was disheartened by political infighting and worried about how the USSR would be run after his death. In late 1922 and early 1923, he dictated what became known as his “testament,” in which he expressed regret at the direction the Soviet government had taken. He was especially critical of Joseph Stalin, then general secretary of the Communist Party. Stalin's aggressive behavior had brought him into conflict with Lenin.

Lenin died in 1924, but his legacy lives on. The Bolshevik Party's establishment of the world's first socialist state in the largest nation affected every country in the world. The victorious socialist revolution inspired workers with an alternative to capitalism and old imperialist regimes. ■